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Madhvi Parekh's acrylic-on-canvas painting 'Travelling Circus in My Village' (80 x 240 inches, 2024) is one of those large-scale works that simply have to be seen in the flesh. The pixels on your screen cannot come close to reproducing its ambition, its grandeur, its irresistible strangeness. A messianic figure lies at the centre of the triptych, holding a snake aloft like a canopy above his head, the faithful gathering around him slowly. An array of human-animal hybrids fills every corner, the chimeras ranging from a biped cow to a snake with a human head, to a horse that has a human face nestled close to its heart. All the while, a determined-looking man carries a temple on his back. Like the triptychs of Dutch painter Hieronymus Bosch, 'Travelling Circus in My Village' tells a story sequentially, and it seems to acquire new details with every fresh glance. The work is part of *Madhvi Parekh: Remembered Tales*, a solo exhibition at DAG, Delhi, that started on July 11 and shall conclude on August 23.

During an interview, the 83-year-old artist spoke about the work ethic that has stood her in good stead throughout her six-decade career. Parekh said: "My father was a schoolteacher and a devoted Gandhian. It was very important to him that we shouldn't waste even a second of our time; everything had to be accounted for. From a young age, I had this habit of not sitting idle, always keeping myself occupied in something or the other. When I started drawing, this habit extended itself into my practice."

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Initially urged by her husband (the artist Manu Parekh) to start drawing, Madhvi charted her own course. Swiss-German artist Paul Klee's work was one of the starting points. But when you observe her early sketches from half a century ago (many of which are also a part of the exhibition), you see how Parekh assimilated a lot of influences in her work—Klee, Spanish artist Joan Miró, folk art from around the world—but the resultant style is truly original. She still tries to draw every day, a habit that she says is akin to women drawing rangoli or alpana in their houses.

"When you do something every day, the art kind of flows out of your hands eventually," says Parekh. "In Maharashtra, in Gujarat, in the south Indian states as well, you see the women who make alpana on the floor every day. My sister does it too, and her patterns have the straightest, most beautiful lines...you should look at her swastikas. My lines are nowhere near as straight, but my husband says that my lines are strong."

Fables, folktales and mythologies are never far from the picture in Parekh's work. In 'Two Scarecrows in My Rice Field' (acrylic-on-canvas, 60 x 120 in, 2024), you will find a crow in a corner, next to a pitcher—a reference to the fable of the clever crow who used pebbles to reach the water at the bottom of a pitcher. At the bottom of the frame in 'Goddess Durga' (acrylic-on-canvas, 72 x